

July 30, 2026 03:08 AM GMT

Qualcomm Inc. | North America

# Apple Exit Accelerates Diversification

| WHAT'S CHANGED         |          |          |
|------------------------|----------|----------|
| Qualcomm Inc. (QCOM.O) | From     | To       |
| Price Target           | \$231.00 | \$220.00 |

| AlphaSignals Earnings Reaction |                                    |                                          |
|--------------------------------|------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| Unchanged                      | In-line                            | Modest revision lower                    |
| Impact to our thesis           | Financial results versus consensus | Direction of next 12-month consensus EPS |

Source: Company data, Morgan Stanley Research

Qualcomm’s diversification is occurring faster than expected as Apple exits, but the transition is not seamless: near-term margin dilution is meaningful and execution risk remains. We stay EW, as we see a balanced risk/reward.

## Key Takeaways

- Apple: iPhone 18 share is below the prior 20% view, accelerating the modem wind-down, though QTL royalties still appear intact.
- Gross margin: AI ramps faster than expected, but early custom silicon is lower margin, pressuring gross profit before merchant products scale.
- Auto: Exit-rate revenue rises to ~\$7B from \$6B, reinforcing automotive as Qualcomm’s strongest near-term diversification engine.
- AI: The \$5B FY27 target is thesis-changing, but execution and mix remain key as Qualcomm builds toward higher-value merchant products.
- Remain EW, PT to \$220.

Fiscal Q3 results were broadly in line, with revenue at the high end of guidance, while gross margins remained the key near-term pressure point due to higher input costs and less favorable chip mix within the premium handset tier. The September-quarter guide was also broadly in line on revenue but slightly below consensus on earnings, as continued cost and mix pressures weigh on QCT margins; pricing actions should help, though the benefit will take several quarters to flow through.

**The Apple to AI transition isn't completely seamless - but having a trillion dollar AI market to diversify into certainly helps.** Qualcomm’s market share of the iPhone 18 is below the 20% that they had initially forecast - we think because Apple is no longer serving the mm wave sku - which is a bit of an incremental headwind, Initial AI revenues are higher than expected, but lower gross margin initially, so our overall gross profit comes down more than revenue.

It's our sense that the path here could be a little bumpy. the first AI wins will likely have less Qualcomm design, so the margins are lower, with merchant products

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| Qualcomm Inc. (QCOM.O, QCOM US)           |                 |        |        |        |
|-------------------------------------------|-----------------|--------|--------|--------|
| Semiconductors   United States of America |                 |        |        |        |
| Stock Rating                              | Equal-weight    |        |        |        |
| Industry View                             | Attractive      |        |        |        |
| Price target                              | \$220.00        |        |        |        |
| Shr price, close (Jul 29, 2026)           | \$155.68        |        |        |        |
| Mkt cap, curr (mm)                        | \$168,311       |        |        |        |
| 52-Week Range                             | \$259.92-121.99 |        |        |        |
| Fiscal Year Ending                        | 09/25           | 09/26e | 09/27e | 09/28e |
| ModelWare EPS (\$)                        | 9.69            | 8.38   | 7.15   | 9.12   |
| EPS (\$)§                                 | 11.90           | 10.80  | 10.99  | 13.37  |
| EPS (\$)***                               | 12.05           | 10.51  | 10.10  | 12.38  |
| P/E                                       | 17.2            | 18.6   | 21.8   | 17.1   |
| Div yld (%)                               | 2.1             | 2.3    | 2.4    | 2.4    |

Unless otherwise noted, all metrics are based on Morgan Stanley ModelWare framework  
§ = Consensus data is provided by Refinitiv Estimates  
\*\*\* = Based on consensus methodology  
e = Morgan Stanley Research estimates

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starting to ramp next year. But the AI opportunity is certainly large enough that the diversification thesis is stronger than we would have expected a few months ago.

**Smartphone: China Android bottoms, Apple worse, Samsung at run rate.** China Android related weakness in the first half is said to be largely behind them, though the memory shortage is still a challenge. The premium tier where Qualcomm is more exposed is a bit stronger, with the brunt of the weakness on the low end. Meanwhile, share of the Samsung (covered by Shawn Kim) handset market has stabilized at about 70%, the longer term run rate, vs. the more elevated 2025 number.

In terms of Apple, covered by Erik Woodring, guidance had been for Qualcomm to lose 80% share of the iPhone 18, which we think was based on the mm wave versions remaining with Qualcomm, by mutual decision, that number is lower. Qualcomm still has the content in the 17, which will linger until next year, at which point Apple QCT revenues will be minimal, largely as expected. On the positive side, the Apple royalty looks to be intact, as management has been saying, as with renewal in April of 2027 we think that Qualcomm would likely be disclosing by now that Qualcomm will be challenged.

**AI ramping faster, but at some cost to gross margins.** AI will ramp to about \$600 mm in the December quarter, but as a result margins are under pressure. We think that the initial ramp of AI products is likely the lower margin, lower value products, transitioning to higher margin products fully developed by Qualcomm next year. This is showing up in gross margin commentary for next year.

**Automotive targets higher.** Automotive continues to be a solid success story for Qualcomm, who has become the largest automotive semiconductor supplier. The company indicated automotive revenues would exit the year at a \$7 b run rate, higher than the previous \$6 bn target. For now, automotive is the best diversification aspect for Qualcomm, though longer term it could be dwarfed by the AI opportunity.

**Details on the quarter:** Revenue in the quarter of \$9.95bn (down 6.2% q/q and down 4.0% y/y) came in slightly ahead of the Street at \$9.69bn and our estimate of \$9.67bn. On a segment basis, QCT revenue was \$8.5bn (down ~6.3% q/q and 5.4% y/y) and QTL was \$1.3bn. Non-GAAP gross margin came in at ~54.0%, below the Street and our estimate of 55.6% and 56.0%, respectively. EPS of \$2.21 was in-line with the Street at \$2.23 and our estimate of \$2.18.

**Changes to estimates:** For CY26 we now model revenue/gross margin/EPS of \$41.0bn/53.7%/\$9.19 vs. our prior \$40.3bn/55.1%/\$9.28. For CY27 we model revenue/gross margin/EPS of \$47.3bn/52.0%/\$10.88 vs. our prior of \$49.2 / 53.8% / \$11.45.

**Thoughts on the stock:** We continue to be a bit cautious; while the management team has executed nicely, we don't take AI penetration for granted. The \$5 bn forecast for AI next year from the analyst day was larger than we thought, and we upgraded the stock from UW to EW as a result post the analyst day - \$5 bn of diversification revenue is thesis changing. But carving out a higher margin defensible position in AI will take time, and with the leaders in AI processors trading at a lower

multiple we do see better risk reward elsewhere.

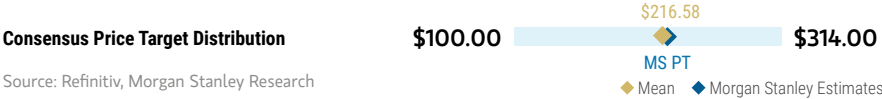
That said, for patient investors, there could be quite a bit of optionality here, and the history of strong execution and diversification into other markets does boost our confidence. But we remain EW. Regarding our price target, our revised estimates lower CY27 MW EPS (includes SBC) to \$7.85. Applying the same 28x multiple, our price target declines from \$231 to \$220.

Risk Reward – Qualcomm Inc. (QCOM.O)

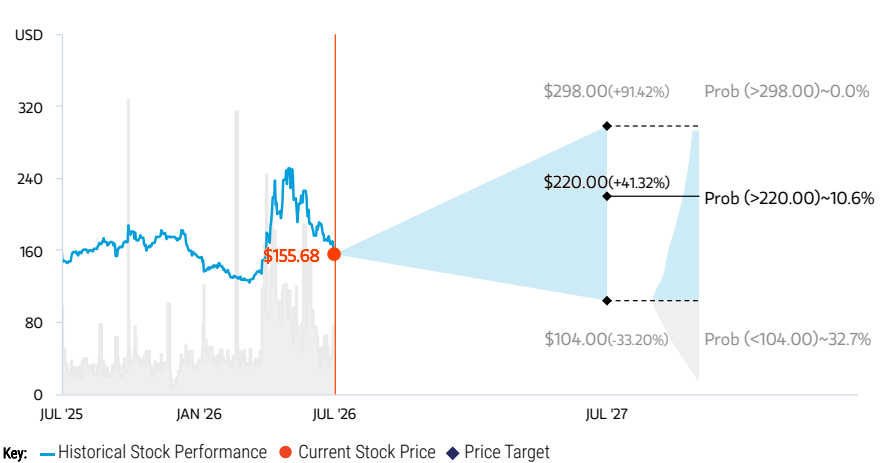
Key edge AI enabler, but wide range of outcomes with smartphone and data center

PRICE TARGET \$220.00

We use a 28x (the midpoint of QCOM's historical range) MW PE multiple on \$7.85 in CY2027 earnings (includes stock based compensation), as we believe new data center revenue is offsetting a muted smartphone cycle from memory constraints. This is roughly 20x Non-GAAP EPS of \$10.88.

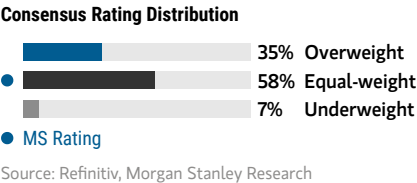


RISK REWARD CHART AND OPTIONS IMPLIED PROBABILITIES (12M)



EQUAL-WEIGHT THESIS

- Handset volumes seem likely to be pressured by severe memory shortage, starting at the low end and becoming more pervasive as the year goes on
- Diversification into automotive has been very strong, and new data center initiatives look promising near-term but remain a show-me story longer-term
- The data center AI opportunity is obviously so large that even a modicum of success can make a difference even to a larger company like Qualcomm, but getting to critical mass is also very difficult. We are watching developments here closely.



| BULL CASE                                                                                                                                                      | \$298.00 | BASE CASE                                                                                                                                                                                | \$220.00 | BEAR CASE                                                                                                                     | \$104.00 |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| 34X Base Case CY26 MW EPS of \$8.76                                                                                                                            |          | 28x CY27 MW EPS of \$7.85                                                                                                                                                                |          | 20X Bear Case CY26 MW EPS of \$5.21                                                                                           |          |
| Exposure to premium market shields QCOM from most of memory headwinds. Autos, IoT, and Data Center scale quickly to diversify away from the smartphone market. |          | While we are expecting a muted smartphone cycle from memory constraints, the new data center revenue is offsetting headwinds. We are valuing it at the midpoint of their historic range. |          | Memory constraints worse than expected, smartphone is pressured even at the high end. Diversification story fails to develop. |          |

Risk Reward – Qualcomm Inc. (QCOM.O)

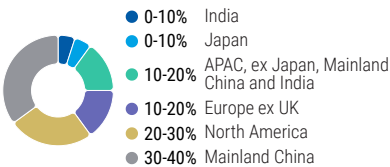
KEY EARNINGS INPUTS

| Drivers                   | Sep 2025 | Sep 2026e | Sep 2027e | Sep 2028e |
|---------------------------|----------|-----------|-----------|-----------|
| GAAP Revenue (\$, mm)     | 44,283   | 42,991    | 44,539    | 52,345    |
| Non-GAAP Gross Margin (%) | 55.9     | 54.2      | 52.2      | 52.7      |
| Non-GAAP EPS (\$)         | 12.05    | 10.51     | 10.10     | 12.38     |
| Inventory (\$, mm)        | 6,526    | 6,535     | 8,178     | 8,411     |
| DOI (\$)                  | 122.3    | 121.2     | 140.3     | 124.0     |

INVESTMENT DRIVERS

- Smartphone market growth and Qualcomm's share in chipsets
- Revenue diversification (automotive & IoT) beyond handsets

GLOBAL REVENUE EXPOSURE



Source: Morgan Stanley Research Estimate  
View explanation of regional hierarchies [here](#)

MS ALPHA MODELS

|             |                     |             |                    |
|-------------|---------------------|-------------|--------------------|
| 4/5<br>BEST | 24 Month<br>Horizon | 3/5<br>MOST | 3 Month<br>Horizon |
|-------------|---------------------|-------------|--------------------|

Source: Refinitiv, FactSet, Morgan Stanley Research; 1 is the highest favored Quintile and 5 is the least favored Quintile

RISKS TO PT/RATING

RISKS TO UPSIDE

- Memory constraints ease faster than expected
- Android market is more resilient
- Apple transition is slow
- Non-handset business scales faster than expected

RISKS TO DOWNSIDE

- Smartphone memory headwinds worse than expected
- Apple internal silicon timeline brought forward
- Share loss to competitors
- Diversification story fails to develop

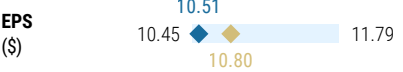
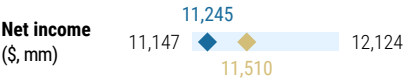
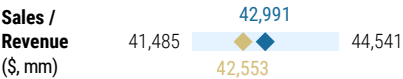
OWNERSHIP POSITIONING

|                            |       |  |
|----------------------------|-------|--|
| Inst. Owners, % Active     | 39.6% |  |
| HF Sector Long/Short Ratio | 2.1x  |  |
| HF Sector Net Exposure     | 29.5% |  |

Refinitiv; MSPB Content. Includes certain hedge fund exposures held with MSPB. Information may be inconsistent with or may not reflect broader market trends. Long/Short Ratio = Long Exposure / Short exposure. Sector % of Total Net Exposure = (For a particular sector: Long Exposure - Short Exposure) / (Across all sectors: Long Exposure – Short Exposure).

MS ESTIMATES VS. CONSENSUS

FY Sep 2026e



Source: Refinitiv, Morgan Stanley Research

# Financial Summary

## Exhibit 1: Income Statement Summary

QCOM: Snapshot for the quarter ended June 2026

| Income Statement |           |            |            |            |          |            |          |            |           |
|------------------|-----------|------------|------------|------------|----------|------------|----------|------------|-----------|
| Qtr Results:     | Actual    |            |            | Lst Qtr    | QoQ      | Lst Yr     | YoY      | Consensus  | MSe       |
| Revenue          | \$9,947.0 |            |            | \$10,599.0 | -6.2%    | \$10,365.0 | -4.0%    | \$9,694.9  | \$9,671.2 |
| Gross Margin     | 54.0%     |            |            | 54.7%      | -69 bps  | 56.2%      | -221 bps | 55.6%      | 56.0%     |
| EPS              | \$2.21    |            |            | \$2.65     | (\$0.44) | \$2.77     | (\$0.56) | \$2.23     | \$2.18    |
| Nxt Qtr Outlook: | Low       | High       | Midpoint   |            |          |            |          |            |           |
| Revenue          | \$9,700.0 | \$10,500.0 | \$10,100.0 |            | 1.5%     | \$11,270.0 | -10.4%   | \$10,068.7 | \$9,522.8 |
| EPS              | \$2.05    | \$2.25     | \$2.15     |            | (\$0.06) | \$3.02     | (\$0.87) | \$2.38     | \$2.10    |

Source: Morgan Stanley Research estimates, FactSet, Company data

## Exhibit 2: Income Statement Variance

| MW financials (excl 1x items), \$ MMs except per share |                   |                 |                        |                  |
|--------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|-----------------|------------------------|------------------|
|                                                        | Reported<br>F3Q26 | MS Est<br>F3Q26 | Diff: Act.<br>vs. Est. | Per sh.<br>Diff. |
| Revenues                                               | 9,947.0           | 9,671.2         | 275.8                  | 0.26             |
| COGs                                                   | 4,604.0           | 4,275.2         | 328.8                  | (0.31)           |
| Gross Profit                                           | 5,343.0           | 5,396.0         | (53.0)                 | (0.05)           |
| GM %                                                   | 53.7%             | 55.8%           | -2.1%                  |                  |
| R&D                                                    | 2,511.0           | 2,638.2         | (127.2)                | 0.12             |
| SG&A                                                   | 886.0             | 787.1           | 98.9                   | (0.09)           |
| Other Opex                                             | 0.0               | 0.0             | 0.0                    | NM               |
| Total Opex                                             | 3,397.0           | 3,425.3         | (28.3)                 | 0.03             |
| Op. Income                                             | 1,946.0           | 1,970.7         | (24.7)                 | (0.02)           |
| Op. M %                                                | 19.6%             | 20.4%           | -0.8%                  |                  |
| Taxes                                                  | 337.0             | 331.5           | 5.5                    | NM               |
| Net Income                                             | 2,297.0           | 1,569.2         | 727.8                  | 0.69             |
| EPS                                                    | \$2.15            | \$1.48          | \$0.67                 | 0.67             |

Source: Company data, Morgan Stanley Research estimates



# Risk Reward Reference links

1. View explanation of Options Probabilities methodology - [Options\\_Probabilities\\_Exhibit\\_Link.pdf](#)
2. View descriptions of Risk Rewards Themes - [RR\\_Themes\\_Exhibit\\_Link.pdf](#)
3. View explanation of regional hierarchies - [GEG\\_Exhibit\\_Link.pdf](#)
4. View explanation of Theme/Exposure methodology - [ESG\\_Sustainable\\_Solutions\\_External\\_Link.pdf](#)
5. View explanation of HERS methodology - [ESG\\_HERS\\_External\\_Link.pdf](#)



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(as of June 30, 2026)

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| Stock Rating Category | Coverage Universe |            | Investment Banking Clients (IBC) |                |                      | Other Material Investment Services Clients (MISC) |                       |
|-----------------------|-------------------|------------|----------------------------------|----------------|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|
|                       | Count             | % of Total | Count                            | % of Total IBC | % of Rating Category | Count                                             | % of Total Other MISC |
| Overweight/Buy        | 1544              | 42%        | 453                              | 49%            | 29%                  | 757                                               | 44%                   |
| Equal-weight/Hold     | 1577              | 43%        | 390                              | 42%            | 25%                  | 769                                               | 44%                   |
| Not-Rated/Hold        | 3                 | 0%         | 1                                | 0%             | 33%                  | 1                                                 | 0%                    |
| Underweight/Sell      | 544               | 15%        | 89                               | 10%            | 16%                  | 204                                               | 12%                   |
| Total                 | 3,668             |            | 933                              |                |                      | 1731                                              |                       |

Data include common stock and ADRs currently assigned ratings. Investment Banking Clients are companies from whom Morgan Stanley received investment banking compensation in the last 12 months. Due to rounding off of decimals, the percentages provided in the "% of total" column may not add up to exactly 100 percent.

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Attractive (A): The analyst expects the performance of his or her industry coverage universe over the next 12-18 months to be attractive vs. the relevant broad market benchmark, as indicated below.

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Cautious (C): The analyst views the performance of his or her industry coverage universe over the next 12-18 months with caution vs. the relevant broad market benchmark, as indicated below.

Benchmarks for each region are as follows: North America - S&P 500; Latin America - relevant MSCI country index or MSCI Latin America Index; Europe - MSCI Europe; Japan - TOPIX; Asia - relevant MSCI country index or MSCI sub-regional index or MSCI AC Asia Pacific ex Japan Index.

## Stock Price, Price Target and Rating History (See Rating Definitions)

Qualcomm Inc. (QCOM.O) - As of 07/30/26 GMT in USD  
Industry : Semiconductors

Effective January 13, 2014, the stocks covered by Morgan Stanley Asia Pacific will be rated relative to the analyst's industry (or industry team's) coverage.

Effective January 13, 2014, the industry view benchmarks for Morgan Stanley Asia Pacific are as follows: relevant MSCI country index or MSCI sub-regional index or MSCI AC Asia Pacific ex Japan Index.

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## INDUSTRY COVERAGE: Semiconductors

| COMPANY (TICKER)                      | RATING (AS OF)  | PRICE* (07/29/2026) |
|---------------------------------------|-----------------|---------------------|
| <b>Joseph Moore</b>                   |                 |                     |
| Advanced Micro Devices (AMD.O)        | E (06/09/2024)  | \$429.56            |
| Aeva Technologies Inc (AEVA.O)        | E (07/19/2021)  | \$13.99             |
| Allegro Microsystems Inc (ALGM.O)     | O (02/13/2026)  | \$42.21             |
| Ambarella Inc (AMBA.O)                | O (03/29/2016)  | \$69.19             |
| Amkor Technology Inc (AMKR.O)         | E (11/08/2023)  | \$42.73             |
| Analog Devices Inc. (ADI.O)           | O (11/16/2023)  | \$353.37            |
| Astera Labs Inc (ALAB.O)              | O (05/11/2025)  | \$249.74            |
| Broadcom Inc. (AVGO.O)                | O (06/09/2024)  | \$370.32            |
| Cerebras Systems (CBRS.O)             | O (06/08/2026)  | \$169.39            |
| GlobalFoundries Inc (GFS.O)           | E (10/28/2024)  | \$47.07             |
| Intel Corporation (INTC.O)            | E (02/22/2023)  | \$81.88             |
| IonQ Inc (IONQ.N)                     | E (04/25/2023)  | \$31.99             |
| Marvell Technology Group Ltd (MRVL.O) | E (09/14/2015)  | \$163.40            |
| Microchip Technology Inc. (MCHP.O)    | E (07/10/2024)  | \$71.37             |
| Micron Technology Inc. (MU.O)         | O (10/06/2025)  | \$739.00            |
| Navitas Semiconductor Corp (NVT.S.O)  | U (04/06/2025)  | \$9.74              |
| NVIDIA Corp. (NVDA.O)                 | O (03/16/2023)  | \$190.01            |
| NXP Semiconductor NV (NXPI.O)         | O (02/11/2025)  | \$240.98            |
| ON Semiconductor Corp. (ON.O)         | ++              | \$78.86             |
| Qorvo Inc (QRVO.O)                    | E (10/28/2025)  | \$89.50             |
| Qualcomm Inc. (QCOM.O)                | E (06/24/2026)  | \$155.68            |
| Quantinuum (QNT.O)                    | E (06/29/2026)  | \$47.34             |
| SanDisk Corporation. (SNDK.O)         | O (03/03/2025)  | \$1,015.89          |
| Semtech Corp. (SMTC.O)                | E (04/06/2025)  | \$103.55            |
| Silicon Laboratories Inc. (SLAB.O)    | E (01/19/2021)  | \$216.44            |
| Skyworks Solutions Inc (SWKS.O)       | E (11/28/2018)  | \$61.19             |
| Texas Instruments (TXN.O)             | U (04/13/2020)  | \$271.30            |
| Wolfspeed, INC (WOLF.N)               | NR (04/06/2025) | \$20.06             |

|                                     |                |  |          |
|-------------------------------------|----------------|--|----------|
| Lee Simpson                         |                |  |          |
| Arm Holdings plc (ARM.O)            | E (04/07/2026) |  | \$224.89 |
| Cadence Design Systems Inc (CDNS.O) | O (02/14/2024) |  | \$332.76 |
| Synopsys Inc. (SNPS.O)              | E (02/27/2026) |  | \$373.69 |

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\* Historical prices are not split adjusted.